

One request line, three stages.

Far-future bets, researched honestly: the karaoke world (market, KJ software, rotation culture), the DJ request economy (crowded - the competitors are named inside), the platform-expansion history of when vertical #2 works, and the one-engine-three-modes architecture. Every phase has measurable gates, not dates.

Verdicts

Live-band karaoke (Phase 1: Coreyoke-style residencies) — GO

Uber-Eats-shaped adjacency: ~85-90% code reuse (QR flow, Stripe Connect, tip-sorted queue port unchanged), same LA bar/booker channel as the open-mic beachhead, and the customer already runs LiveQueue's exact model manually — printed songbooks, handwritten sign-ups, open cash-\$20 queue jumps — so it's digitization, not behavior change. Zero purpose-built incumbents found for live-band-karaoke queues (state of the art is paper and PDF templates). TouchTunes Fast Pass proves at 65-75k venues that bar patrons pay to jump a music queue. Small circuit (Coreyoke, Casual Encounters, The Moon Units) is a credibility beachhead, not a scale market — enter it for references and adjacency, and enter soon: Choons is already testing paid skip-the-line for karaoke, and the paper-signup window depreciates.

Mainstream KJ karaoke (18k weekly nights, rotation mode) — CAUTION

Real market (12x the dedicated-bar count; KJs gross \$125-200/night so \$4.99 is trivial; incumbents OpenKJ/Karaoki/KaraFun do playback+rotation but zero money layer) — but LiveQueue's signature mechanic is culturally toxic here: KJs refuse \$20 queue-jumps on principle, self-label 'rotation Nazi', and tip jars carry 'tips don't affect rotation' disclaimers. Shipping tip-to-jump into a KJ night poisons the distribution channel. Requires net-new engineering (round-robin rotation engine with persistent singer positions, stacked songs, break handling — a replacement ordering strategy, not a tweak) plus an inverted pitch: fairness tooling + gratuity-only tips at 0%. ~7 weeks build. Only start after live-band pilots prove the karaoke surface.

DJ — CAUTION

Most crowded possible vertical: 10+ active products (RequestNow claims 4,000+ DJs; tip.dj takes 10%; DJFY, Lime DJ, NoSongRequests, BeatTribe, Emsi, TipTunez...), working DJs are openly hostile to requests ('a slightly more selective TouchTunes jukebox'), bar owners expect a revenue cut that collides with the 0% moat, and only ~60-65% code reuse — the fan page loses its ranked queue and Stripe must be reworked to manual-capture authorize/capture/release. The economic wedge is real and unoccupied (nobody offers 0%-of-tips + cheap sub; RequestNow gates Apple Pay tips behind \$30/mo), and DemandDJ/Jukestar's deaths validate LiveQueue's architecture — but per Moore this pin shares the engine and NOT the channel. Sequence as pin #3, entered when KJ/DJ crossover hosts pull LiveQueue there. Realistic per-night tip scale is ~\$100-200, so pitch crowd control, not riches.

The one cultural landmine

THE collision: rotation fairness vs pay-to-jump. Mainstream KJ culture treats paid queue-jumps as bribery (hosts refuse \$20 on principle, self-label 'rotation Nazi', tip jars carry 'tips don't affect rotation' disclaimers) while live-band karaoke openly runs cash-\$20 jumps. Resolution: make queue-boosting a per-event, host-controlled toggle with defaults set by sub-vertical - live-band mode defaults boost ON (digitizing the existing \$20 line), KJ rotation mode defaults gratuity-only with an explicit fan-facing 'tips thank your host and never change the rotation' label; never silently mix the two, and pitch KJs fairness tooling + 0%-of-tips gratuity, never pay-to-skip (Choons' FastPass-without-a-fairness-story is the cautionary competitor). Secondary conflict: tip-sorted queue vs round-robin is a data-structure fork - resolved by keeping one requests table and branching only the ordering/render strategy on `queue_mode`. Tertiary: the band-sized browse grid vs 15k-song books - resolved by search-first UI in karaoke mode.

DJ collisions: Three real collisions. (1) Brand-mechanic collision: 'tips move you up the queue' is LiveQue's signature, but for DJs it is an anti-promise - paid position implies obligation to play, which DJs despise ('a slightly more selective TouchTunes jukebox'). Resolution: DJ mode has no visible queue at all; money is authorized, not captured, until the DJ accepts - refund-on-veto converts the signature mechanic into 'paid request, money back if not played'. (2) Venue-cut collision: bar owners expect a cut of request revenue (TouchTunes pays venues at 65-75k locations), and any rev-share breaks the 0%-of-tips moat that defines the company. Resolution: structurally refuse venue rev-share - sell DJ-paid SaaS, target residencies and mobile gigs where the DJ owns the room, and walk away from venues demanding a cut rather than compromise the 0% promise (the Groupon lesson: reject verticals whose economics attack the core moat). (3) Payment-path fork risk: manual-capture must not leak into band/karaoke tip flow - isolate behind the mode flag and keep all gratuity immediate-charge.

Architecture: one engine, three modes

Code reuse across modes: ~70%. Shared core: QR/slug entry to the `customer.html` fan web page, no app download - identical in all three modes and the direct counter to app-gated competitors (Choons is iOS-only); Stripe Connect Express money rail: stripe-onboard, stripe-status, stripe-create-tip, stripe-webhook edge functions, destination charges, Apple Pay, 0% platform fee - the trust moat ports untouched to KJs (a fairness-obsessed culture) and DJs (vs tip.dj's 10% cut and RequestNow's \$30/mo Apple Pay gate); requests table + Supabase realtime sync between fan page and performer dashboard - one pipe for all modes; only the ordering/acceptance policy differs; Buy-a-Drink mode (`artist_settings.drink_mode`, `drink_price`) - works verbatim in all three verticals; it is gratuity that never touches the queue, which is exactly what mainstream karaoke culture demands; Tip presets (`tip_amounts`), free-request-always-one-tap fallback, tip celebration/confetti layer; Performer account system: artists + `artist_settings`, slug routing, login, payout setup UI - a KJ or DJ onboards identically to a musician; Song library + bulk import (`songs` table, import-spotify) - reused by band and karaoke; optional for DJ; Per-night recap and reputation: `gigs`, `played_songs`, reviews, gig-recap-sweeper - a KJ night or DJ set recap works unchanged and is a retention hook in every vertical

Karaoke mode: ~7 weeks (Ship in two phases because they are culturally different products: Phase 1 live-band karaoke = today's tip-sorted queue with singer-forward labeling (1-2 weeks, pilotable at a Coreyoke-style residency, NO rotation engine needed - that circuit already runs a tip-ordered queue on paper); Phase 2 KJ rotation mode = the real build below, only when targeting the 18k weekly KJ nights; Singer-forward request card: `requester_name` (column already exists on requests) becomes required and primary - 'KAYLA - Don't Stop Believin' instead of song-first; trivial relabel; Round-robin rotation engine (the genuine net-new engineering): singer auto-moves to bottom after performing, position persists across

songs, stacked songs per singer preserved, new singers join at rotation bottom - this REPLACES sortRequestQueue()'s tip-sort as an alternate ordering strategy, it is not a tweak to it; Singer identity continuity: lightweight per-event singer record keyed by device token so repeat requests from the same phone group into one rotation slot; No-show and break handling: KJ skip/hold/remove controls; skipped singer keeps position for one round then drops; on_break status excluded from rotation without losing place)

DJ mode: ~6 weeks (Request-inbox semantics, not a queue: fans see status only (pending / accepted 'coming up' / declined / played) - never a ranked position, because DJ mode makes no ordering promise; Veto-first flow: accept/decline dashboard with one-tap canned decline messages; money only captured if accepted - the pitch is 'a bouncer for your booth', never 'get more requests' (working DJs read more-requests as an anti-feature); Stripe rework (the real engineering): manual-capture PaymentIntents - authorize on request, capture on accept/play, auto-release on decline or set end; new branch in stripe-create-tip plus new capture/release functions and webhook cases; drink/gratuities tips stay on the existing immediate-charge path; Song rules engine: banned-song list, per-song/genre minimum prices (productize the DJ PressPlay 'fines list' including deterrent pricing), global minimum tip; No-singer identity: requester name optional/hidden; paid shout-outs/dedications as a first-class second request kind (Emsi/TipTunez pattern))

The wedges and the pitches

Karaoke → LA live-band karaoke residencies first (Coreyoke, Casual Encounters, The Moon Units — named, reachable, decade-long weekly gigs), NOT the 18k mainstream KJ nights; KJ rotation mode comes only after live-band proof

“Your paper sign-up sheet and the cash \$20 to jump the line, on a QR code — Apple Pay, you keep 100% of every tip, and we never touch your playback.”

DJ → Bar residencies and party-style mobile-DJ gigs where the DJ owns the room — skip weddings (pre-event planning software, Vibo's \$99-179/mo turf) and skip credibility-driven club nights (culturally hostile, venue-cut economics)

“A bouncer for your booth: set per-song prices like a fines list, veto anything with one tap, fans are only charged if you actually play it — and you keep 100%.”

Gates (conditions, not dates)

Before Live-band karaoke Phase 1 (tip-sorted queue with singer-forward labeling, ~1-2 weeks):

- Open-mic beachhead demonstrably won: Centola 25% saturation threshold hit at the target LA open mic AND core weekly growth has visibly plateaued (Winters rule: second products ship when they have to, not when they can)
- Reference machine exists: at least a handful of open-mic performers who will vouch to bar bookers (Moore: pragmatists buy on references from people like them)
- Stripe Connect tip flow is boring — no open payment bugs, re-onboarding solved, real tip volume flowing weekly
- The Winters KPI is written down before building: karaoke counts as working ONLY if it inflects TOTAL LiveQue growth (venues, requests, Pro subs), not if it achieves standalone niche traction
- One named pilot committed (e.g. a Coreyoke Wednesday at Basement Tavern) — no build without a booked room

Before KJ rotation mode / Phase 2 (round-robin engine, ~7 weeks):

- 2-3 live-band karaoke acts using LiveQue weekly for 4+ consecutive weeks with measurable tips-per-night
- Live-band karaoke has inflected total company metrics, not just its own chart
- Gratuity-only tip semantics (tips never touch the queue) validated in the field via the per-event toggle before any rotation code is written
- Coexistence tested: LiveQue runs alongside a KJ's OpenKJ/Karaoki/KaraFun playback rig at a real night without touching playback
- At least one mainstream KJ recruited as design partner who explicitly wants fairness tooling + 0% gratuity (never pitch pay-to-skip)

Before DJ mode (request inbox + manual-capture Stripe, ~6 weeks):

- Karaoke vertical won and inflecting total growth (pin #2 knocked down before pin #3)
- Pull, not push: KJ/DJ crossover hosts already on LiveQue are asking to use it for DJ sets — this is the only channel that avoids fighting RequestNow's 4,000-DJ head start cold
- Manual-capture PaymentIntents branch scoped and isolated so authorize/capture/release can never leak into the band/karaoke immediate-charge tip path
- Venue-cut red line ratified: LiveQue structurally refuses venue rev-share and walks away from rooms demanding a cut (Groupon lesson: reject verticals whose economics attack the 0% moat)
- Sub-segment locked in writing: bar residencies + party-style mobile gigs only; weddings (Vibo's turf) and credibility club nights explicitly out of scope

Competition, honestly

Where incumbents actually sit: RequestNow is the closest direct competitor (SMS-first, dedicated phone number, claims 4,000+ DJs, \$7-30/mo) but its money layer is weak — mostly Venmo/CashApp links, with native Apple Pay/card tips gated to the \$30/mo Pro tier. tip.dj has real Stripe Connect rails but takes 10% of every transaction. Vibo owns wedding DJs (\$99-179/mo) with a pre-event planning product that has no live tipping at all — that is a different product and LiveQue should not fight it. TouchTunes owns the

VENUE relationship in 65-75k bars with Fast Pass/Dynamic Fast Pass (at-scale proof patrons pay for queue priority) but it is venue-installed infrastructure with rev-share to venues and operators — it validates the mechanic while occupying exactly the venue-side position LiveQueue must not take. Choons is the karaoke warning shot: iOS-only, coin-pack IAP FastPass with no fairness story. KJ software (OpenKJ, PCDJ Karaoki, KaraFun at \$199+/mo, Singa) is playback + rotation with zero payments — LiveQueue coexists beside it, never replaces it. LiveQueue's actual differentiation, honestly stated: (1) 0% of tips + \$4.99 sub, priced under everyone, un-copyable by tip.dj (10% IS its business model) and structurally cleaner than RequestNow's paywall; (2) performer-owned, not venue-installed — the KJ/DJ carries LiveQueue across 2-5 rooms, sidestepping TouchTunes' turf and venue-cut demands; (3) the QR/web page with no app download vs Choons' iOS gate and coin abstraction; (4) no playback/streaming dependency, the exact failure that killed Jukestar. What LiveQueue does NOT have: distribution among DJs (RequestNow's 4,000 head start is real) and any presence in weddings — both are reasons to sequence, not reasons to quit.

Cheap moves that keep both doors open (schema only, when we next touch the code)

- Add `artist_settings.mode` text default 'band' (band|karaoke|dj) and `queue_mode` text default 'tip_sort' (tip_sort|rotation) now — one migration, zero behavior change, and every future fork branches on these instead of forking files
- Add `artist_settings.tip_boost_enabled` bool default true now — the per-event tip-semantics toggle (boost vs gratuity-only) is the single load-bearing switch for the entire karaoke culture problem
- Extract `sortRequestQueue()` into a pluggable ordering strategy keyed on `queue_mode` — costs an hour, prevents the tip-sort logic from calcifying as the only possible queue
- Start surfacing requesters' names: `requester_name` already exists on requests — collect and display it in band mode so the singer-forward karaoke card ('KAYLA — Don't Stop Believin') is a relabel, not a rework
- Keep all tips as immediate Stripe destination charges and keep tip logic decoupled from queue-position logic — so the DJ manual-capture branch (authorize/capture/release) bolts on later without touching band/karaoke money
- Vertical-neutral naming everywhere fan-facing: 'performer'/'host', never 'musician'/'band' hardcoded in copy, emails, or legal — the brand must stretch to KJs and DJs without a rename
- Write two rules into the plan doc verbatim: (a) Winters KPI — a new vertical counts only if it inflects TOTAL LiveQueue growth; (b) the red lines — never touch playback or streaming SDKs (Jukestar), never accept venue rev-share (the 0% moat is the company)
- Design songs browse to degrade gracefully to search-first — don't hardcode grid assumptions that break at 15k-song KJ books; defer the `pg_trgm` index itself until karaoke Phase 2
- Do NOT build now: rotation engine, singers table, manual-capture Stripe, `song_rules` — all real engineering that the gates must unlock

Key sources

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